Chapter 3: Qualitative Research Approaches

Ethnography, Phenomenology, Case studies

Ethnography

Ethnography is a qualitative research method used to study cultures and communities by immersing oneself in the participants' natural environment to understand their behaviors, beliefs, and practices.

It involves in-depth observation, interviews, and analysis to provide a rich, detailed picture of a social setting from the perspective of those being studied.

The critical case of Street Corner Society

Street Corner Society: The Social Structure of an Italian Slum is an ethnography written by William Foote Whyte and published in 1943

Overt Participant observation : Identity was not hidden
Key informant strategy: Reliance on local leader ‘Doc; for both access and rapport with community
Long term immersion with community: Roughly four years

Flipside with criticisms;

Direct engagement with illegal activities to gain deeper insight (Fraud of votes, engaged in racketeering)
Doc’s influence on work; rivalry with Chick, his local opponent
Anonymity issues

Types of ethnography

In overt ethnography, the researcher openly declares their role and intentions to the participants (Overt Participation)

In covert ethnography, the researcher does not reveal their identity as a researcher (Covert Participation)

Overt: More ethical, easier communication, but may impact participant behaviour

Covert: Relatively seen as less ethical, more access for the hidden identity, stressful for the researcher

Phenomenology

Phenomenology research is a qualitative approach that explores how individuals experience and make sense of phenomena.

It focuses on understanding the subjective meanings people attach to their lived experiences, rather than seeking objective explanations or cause-and-effect relationships.

Researchers delve into the "what it is like" to experience something, aiming to capture the richness and depth of individual perspectives.

Methods of Phenomenology

Interviews

Observations

Personal narratives

Interview types

Structured Interviews:

Such interview use a fixed set of predetermined questions which are asked in a specific order. There is limited flexibility in such interviews.

Semi-Structured Interviews:

Uses more open-ended core questions. The interviewer can explore unexpected topics and ask follow-up probes while keeping the session focused.

Unstructured Interviews:

Such interviews contain no fixed questions or predetermined order. They begin with a broad opening statement and let the respondent guide the organic flow of conversation.

Class exercise

Create 10/12 semi-structured interview questions for your research report

Case study

Case study research is an in-depth, qualitative research approach that examines a specific real-world phenomenon within its context.

It involves a detailed analysis of a single case or a small number of cases, often using multiple sources of evidence to provide a comprehensive understanding.

Limitations: **Limited generalizability**, **Potential for researcher bias**, **Time-consuming and resource-intensive**, **Difficulty in replication**

Other tools for use in qualitative research

Focus group discussions (FGDs): When a specific, small group of people discuss on the topic of enquiry under the guidance of the researcher (who mainly guides the flow of the discussion, without influencing the responses)

Benefits:
In-depth data (when compared to more rigid surveys)
Time and cost efficiency
Interaction is synergized (participants engage with each other, thereby bringing forth more nuances)

Main Disadvantages:
Groups can act in a counter manner preventing shy individuals from sharing
Dominating individuals could influence what is shared within the group